Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Emily Dickinson's "[Because I could not stop for Death]" and William Cullen Bryant's "Thanatopsis"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of a shared approach to understanding death in Emily Dickinson's "[Because I could not stop for Death]" and William Cullen Bryant's "Thanatopsis" include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
connotation,
controlling image,
denotation,
imagery,
metaphor,
onomatopoeia,
personification,
rhetorical question,
simile,
symbol,
synæsthesia,
theme, and
tone.

Any straightforward, supported (quoting the poems) presentation of a shared understanding of the inevitability of death—human mortality—that reflects on both poets' calm, objective acceptance of the commonality of death will serve.

The prompt asks the student to recognize the poets' shared understanding, not to compare (and contrast) the poems, though, no doubt something in the way of comparison is inevitable; however, the student should not offer what is foundationally a comparison. Certainly, the essay's thesis statement should point to a response that carefully follows the prompt.